

Leshan Giant Buddha

A masterpiece of engineering that is the world's largest stone Buddha



The Giant Buddha, carved out of a cliff at Mount Lingyun, in Leshan, in China's Sichuan province, presides over the intersection of three rivers: the Min, Qingyi, and Dadu. The sculpture was located there not simply to promote Buddhism but, according to legend, to pacify the river gods and help calm the treacherous waters that endangered human life and the smooth passage of ships. Appropriately enough, it depicts the bodhisattva ("enlightened being") Maitreya, a "future buddha," who was believed to rescue those in danger.

Larger than life

Construction of the monument was initiated by Hai Tong, a Chinese monk, in 713 CE; it was completed some 90 years later, after his death. Standing 233 ft

(71 m) high, it is an astonishing feat of engineering and a magnificent example of Buddhist art: seated in tranquil pose and with his hands on his knees, Maitreya has a head that is approximately 46 ft (14 m) high and 33 ft (10 m) wide; his ears are about 23 ft (7 m) long; and his hair forms 1,021 exquisitely carved coils. It is claimed that the tremendous volume of stone that was cut from the Lingyun cliff-face and deposited in the river during the building of the giant statue caused a permanent change in the local river currents, making the surrounding waters calmer and far safer.

An ingenious drainage system was constructed inside the Giant Buddha when it was built to prevent erosion from rainfall. The statue was designated a World Heritage Site in 1996.



△ GIANT STEPS

The Buddha's feet—like most of the statue—are carved from stone. Only the ears are made of different material—wood covered with clay.

▽ MOUNTAIN VIEW

The spectacular Giant Buddha, carved out of the cliff-face at Leshan, gazes over the water toward Mount Emei, one of China's four sacred Buddhist mountains.

If upright, the statue would be **roughly** the **height** of the **Statue of Liberty**

